

Khalid Wani,
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at Western Digital

On Western Digital's multi-brand strategy

We have a chat with Khalid Wani to gain insight into Western Digital's positioning of their massive product portfolio

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Q SanDisk and WD tend to release products around the same time so how do you segment and differentiate products from the two brands even though they're the same on the inside.

Khalid: If you look at the Western Digital portfolio then majority of the products are hard disk drive based products. When you look at our SanDisk portfolio, then it's a complete flash-based portfolio. Our entire MicroSD and USB form-factor products are all SanDisk products and you don't see that in Western Digital. If you come back to Western Digital, then only the SSDs are flash-based products and that's where you probably see the overlap. SanDisk, as a flash-based portfolio is predominantly built with a thought process of addressing the consumer segment. The Western Digital portfolio is built to address the SME, Enterprise and Consumer segments hence you see the Blue, Green

and Black classification. Then there's brand affinity. The reason that we decided to have Western Digital, HGST and SanDisk as individual brands after acquisition is to predominantly ensure that we have a continuity in the market as the brands had in the past. Western Digital as a brand is very well-known when it comes to the channel, the SME and the mid-market enterprise segment for the SSD play. It allows us to consistently make sure that there is no overlap. When you look at SanDisk as a brand, it's a very well-known consumer brand. In the enterprise line, HGST is a well-recognised brand. That's why we have a multi-brand strategy available.

Q And where does G-Technology fit into all of this?

Khalid: G-Technology is a brand that addresses a specialised segment. When you look at Media and Entertainment, then there's a need for a product that can address both the 'big data' and 'fast data' requirements. For example, in an outdoor shoot all the content is created on digital cameras and they need an onsite digital storage which can be utilised in a rugged environment in which data loss doesn't happen. So they need a product that is much more faster, redundant and specialised. While a portion

of the internal components would be the same, the specialised feature set that they have is what allows G-Technology products to be used in the media industry more appropriately. We work with a lot of production houses across the board in India as well as abroad to make sure that we are meeting their needs.

Q How has the segmentation of HDDs on the basis of use cases such as Blue, Black, Green, Red, Gold, Purple, etc. helped with the perception of the WD portfolio? Have consumers started making intelligent decision on the basis of this segmentation?

Khalid: We are a company that has the largest portfolio of products available in that storage space, period. The fact that we believe that we are able to provide a product in a particular use case to ensure that the customer pays for what they want, is very important for us. We don't want a customer, whose requirement is based on a Green SSD paying for a Blue or a Black. We spend a lot of time, money and effort to go out into the market and educate the consumers better. And this is not just in the SSD portfolio but we have this across all our different product portfolios, be it flash, HDD or even microSD portfolio. That segmentation is important for a company like ours wherein the digital storage experience has different needs for different consumers and it's super critical that we communicate that to our consumers.

This segmentation has definitely helped us as a company as well. We believe in the good, better and best positioning that we have on our product portfolio. There's a lot of growth happening in the Indian market happening across segments including the high-performance segment. High-performance gaming is a fast growing segment in India, not just PC but also console and mobile. So you see consumers becoming aware of the fact that they need something like a Black for more performance and we see that segment growing on a YoY basis. When we track our business in India, there are two parameters that we consistently look at - high-performance and high-capacity. And there is a very strong growth that we continue to see in capacity and performance segment. **Q**